

Study of the Traditional Physical Library Card System Used at Wayamba University of Sri Lanka

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1. Introduction

A library is an organized information center that collects, preserves, manages, and provides access to books and other information resources. Before the widespread adoption of computerized library management systems such as Koha, libraries commonly managed their collections and users through **manual, paper-based systems**.

This report examines the **traditional library system used at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka**, with particular attention to the manual methods used to manage library resources and user activities. In this system, information relating to books, users, borrowing and returning transactions, stock, and other library activities was maintained using **library cards, registers, files, issuing tickets, stamps, handwritten entries, and other physical records**.

Although the traditional system is based on physical records, it functions as a complete information-management system in which different records are interconnected. For example, a student's library registration record identifies the borrower, the accession record identifies a particular book, and the issuing ticket and book card connect the borrower with the book during a borrowing transaction.

This study focuses on the traditional library card system and related manual procedures at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka. It covers **library records and registers, book categories, issuing tickets, borrowing and returning procedures, users and staff responsibilities, inter-library loans, stock control, library clearance, and other relevant activities** involved in managing the library through the traditional system.

2. Objectives of the Study

The main objectives of this study of the traditional library system used at the **Wayamba University of Sri Lanka** are:

1. To understand how the library operated using a traditional manual system before the implementation of computerized library-management systems.

2. To identify the different types of users involved in the library system.
3. To identify the physical and documentary components used to operate and manage the system.
4. To understand how books were registered, recorded, and controlled.
5. To understand how students and staff were registered as library members.
6. To study the manual procedures used for issuing and returning books.
7. To understand the purpose and use of library cards and issuing tickets.
8. To examine how different categories of books were classified and controlled according to their borrowing conditions.
9. To identify the registers and other records maintained by the library.
10. To understand the procedures used to identify and control overdue books.
11. To study the methods used for stock verification and the control of missing or lost books.
12. To understand the procedures involved in inter-library loans.
13. To examine the library clearance process for students and staff.
14. To identify the advantages and limitations of the traditional manual library system.
15. To understand how the records and processes of the traditional system relate to the functions of a modern computerized library-management system.

3. Method Used for the Study

The study was conducted primarily through **direct observation, examination of available physical records, and discussions with library personnel** at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka. The purpose was to understand the structure and operation of the traditional manual library system and the records associated with it.

The investigation included the following activities:

- Observing available physical library records and documents.
- Examining registers and other manually maintained records.
- Studying the manual circulation procedures for issuing and returning books.
- Identifying the different categories of library materials and their borrowing conditions.
- Studying the use and purpose of issuing tickets and book cards.
- Examining the relationship between students, staff, books, and the corresponding library records.
- Identifying registers and records used for library administration and resource control.
- Studying available records related to inter-library loans.
- Discussing previous manual library practices with library personnel.
- Comparing the observed practices with the general principles of traditional library-card systems.

As the library has transitioned towards computerized methods, some older manual records are no longer actively maintained. Access to certain records was also limited due to **privacy, confidentiality, preservation, and administrative restrictions**. Furthermore, some of the available documents had not been used or updated for more than ten years.

Therefore, this study does not claim that every historical procedure of the library could be directly observed. Where necessary, a distinction is made between **procedures and practices directly identified at the library** and the general characteristics of traditional library-card systems. This approach ensures that the report reflects the available evidence while acknowledging the limitations of studying a historical manual system.

4. Background of the Traditional Library System

Before computers became common in libraries, information was stored mainly on paper.

A typical traditional library could contain:

- Accession registers
- Cataloguing records
- Shelf lists
- Book cards
- Borrower cards
- Student registers
- Staff registers
- Issue registers
- Return records
- Overdue records
- Fine records
- Stock registers
- Lost-book records
- Inter-library loan registers
- Reports and statistics



The system depended heavily on the physical movement and filing of documents.

For example:

Student → Library Registration → Issuing Ticket → Book → Issue Record → Return Record → Shelf

This chain represents the basic logic of the manual circulation system.

The traditional system therefore functioned as a physical database. Instead of querying a computer database, the librarian searched through registers, cards, files, shelves, and folders.

5. Main Components of the Traditional System

The main components of the traditional library system can be organized into five major groups: **users, library materials, physical records, identification and control tools, and library staff.**

5.1 Users

The main categories of users involved in the library system include:

- Students
- Academic staff
- Administrative staff
- Non-Academic staff
- Library staff

Each category of user is associated with different registration and borrowing requirements according to the library's procedures.

5.2 Library Materials

The library collection includes different categories of materials, such as:

- Lending books
- Schedule reference materials
- Permanent reference materials
- Special collections
- Other library resources

The borrowing and usage conditions differ according to the category of the material. Some materials can be borrowed for a specified period, while certain reference materials are restricted to library use.

5.3 Physical Records

The traditional system relies on various physical registers and records to maintain information about users, books, borrowing activities, and other library operations. Important records include:

- Student register
- Staff registers, including:
 - Register of Permanent Academic Staff
 - Register of Temporary Academic Staff
 - Register of Permanent Administrative Staff
 - Register of Non-Academic Staff
- Accession register
- Issue and return records

- Stock register
- Inter-library loan register
- Fine Book of Late Fines
- Register of Lost Books / Lost and Paid
- Other administrative registers

These records collectively provide the documentary foundation for managing the library's activities in a manual environment.

5.4 Identification and Control Tools

Several physical tools and identifiers are used to organize and control library resources and transactions. These include:

- Library registration numbers
- Accession numbers
- Issuing tickets
- Book cards
- Due-date information
- Library stamps
- Borrower information
- Shelf and location information

These identifiers help connect users, books, and transactions and make it possible for library staff to locate and update the relevant physical records.

5.5 Library Staff

Library staff are responsible for carrying out and maintaining the day-to-day operations of the system. Their responsibilities include:

- Registering users
- Registering and recording books
- Classifying and arranging books
- Issuing library materials
- Receiving returned materials
- Checking and controlling overdue materials
- Maintaining registers and other records
- Maintaining and verifying stock
- Handling inter-library loans
- Assisting library users
- Conducting library clearance procedures

Through these activities, library staff coordinate the different components of the traditional system and ensure that library resources and records are properly maintained.

6. Types of Library Materials

One of the important features identified in the library system at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka is that **library materials are not all treated in the same manner**. Their borrowing conditions differ according to their category.

Based on the observed borrowing system, three main categories are relevant:

6.1 Lending Books

Lending books are materials that eligible users can borrow for a relatively longer period.

According to the procedure observed:

- Lending books can be issued for **two weeks**.
- They are intended to be used outside the library.
- The borrower is required to return the book on or before the specified due date.
- A student can borrow a lending book using one of the **two blue issuing tickets** provided to the student.

6.2 Schedule Reference Books

The second category consists of **schedule reference books**, which can be borrowed for a limited period of **one night**.

These materials have more restricted borrowing conditions because they may be required by multiple library users and the available number of copies may be limited.

A student can borrow a schedule reference book using the **pink issuing ticket**.

6.3 Permanent Reference Books

Permanent reference books are materials that **cannot normally be borrowed for use outside the library**. They are intended to be used within the library premises.

These materials remain available for users who need to consult them for reference purposes. The library determines which materials are placed under permanent reference restrictions.

The borrowing rule can therefore be summarized as:

Permanent Reference → No External Borrowing → Library Use Only

The classification of materials according to their borrowing conditions is an important part of the traditional library system. It represents a set of **library rules and control mechanisms** that determine how each type of material can be accessed and used.

7. Issuing Ticket System

The issuing-ticket system is one of the important components of the traditional library system observed at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka. The tickets are used to control and identify the types of books a student is permitted to borrow.

Each student receives **three issuing tickets**:

- **Two blue issuing tickets**
- **One pink issuing ticket**

The colour of the ticket helps library staff identify the borrowing category associated with the transaction.

Blue Issuing Tickets

The **blue issuing tickets** are used for borrowing lending books.

Blue ticket → Lending book → Two-week loan

Pink Issuing Ticket

The **pink issuing ticket** is used for borrowing schedule reference books.

Pink ticket → Schedule reference → One-night loan

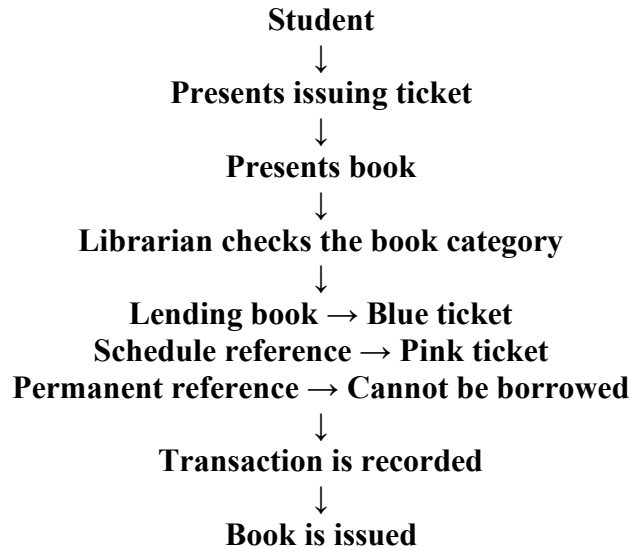
Permanent reference books cannot be borrowed using these tickets because they are restricted to use within the library.

The issuing-ticket system therefore acts as a **physical control mechanism** within the manual library system. Instead of a computerized system automatically checking a student's borrowing privileges, the librarian can use the student's physical tickets to determine the permitted type and number of borrowing transactions.

8. How the Issuing Ticket Works

The issuing ticket functions as a physical **transaction-control mechanism** during the borrowing process. It connects the student, the borrowing entitlement, and the selected book.

A simplified representation of the process is:



During this process, the librarian checks the type of book and the appropriate issuing ticket before completing the transaction. The relevant physical records are then updated as required.

The issuing-ticket system performs a function that is conceptually similar to an **authorization or borrowing-control mechanism in a computerized database**. In the manual system, however, this control is implemented through physical tickets, records, and the librarian's verification rather than through automated database rules.

9. Student Registration Record

Before using the library's borrowing services, a student must first be registered with the library. The student registration record provides the basic information required to identify the student and connect the student with the library's borrowing records.

The student registration record identified during the study contains fields such as:

Field	Description
Student Registration Number	Unique identification number assigned by the university.
Name	Name of the student.
Address	Address of the student.
Library Registration Number	A library-specific identification number assigned according to the order of registration.
Remarks	Additional information relevant to the student's library record.

The **library registration number** is particularly important in the manual system because it provides a library-specific way of identifying the student within the library's records. It can be used when maintaining and locating information related to the student's library activities.

Therefore, the traditional system establishes a relationship between the student's identity, library registration, issuing tickets, and borrowing activities:

Student Registration Number ↔ Library Registration Number ↔ Issuing Ticket ↔ Borrowing Activity

This relationship allows library staff to connect a particular student with the physical records associated with their library transactions.

10. Staff Registration Record

Library services are also provided to eligible staff members who are permitted to use the library collection. Similar to student registration, staff registration allows the library to maintain the necessary information about staff members who use library services.

The staff registration record identified during the study contains information such as:

- Serial number
- Date
- Reader's name
- Email address
- Telephone number
- Department
- Reader's number
- Date of appointment
- Designation
- Permanent address
- Remarks

These details enable the library to identify staff members and maintain records of their use of library services and borrowing activities.

The **staff registration record** therefore represents another important entity within the physical information system of the traditional library. It connects the identity of the staff member with the library's records and related borrowing transactions.

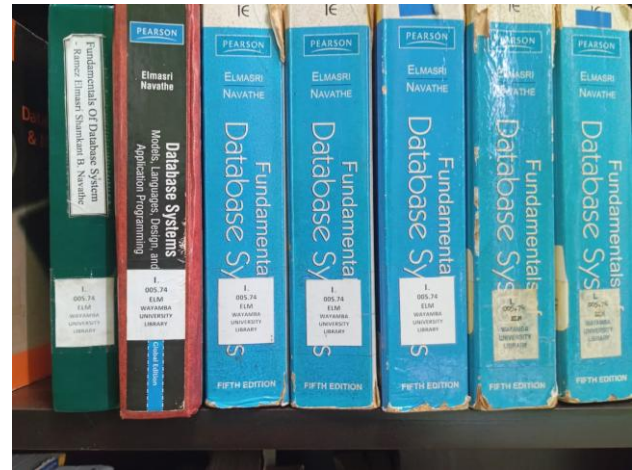
11. Book Identification

Each physical book in the library collection requires a unique identity so that it can be recorded, located, and controlled. One of the most important identifiers used in a traditional library system is the **accession number**.

An accession number identifies a particular physical item within the library collection. Other information associated with a book may include:

Book

- Accession Number
- Title
- Author
- Publisher
- Year of Publication
- Price
- Classification
- Location



The accession number is particularly important because different physical copies of the same title are treated as separate library items.

For example:

Title: Introduction to Computer Science

Copy 1: Accession No. 1001

Copy 2: Accession No. 1002

Although both copies have the same title, their accession numbers distinguish the two physical items.

Therefore, the accession number provides an important link between the **physical book and the library's records**.

12. Accession Register

The **accession register** is one of the important permanent records of a traditional library system. It is used to record books and other resources when they are added to the library collection.

The information recorded in an accession register may include:

- Accession number
- Date of accession
- Author
- Title
- Publisher
- Edition

- Year of publication
- Number of pages
- Source of acquisition
- Price
- Invoice information
- Classification information
- Remarks

The accession register provides a historical record of resources added to the library collection.

13. Book Card, Book Pocket and Due-Date Slip

The traditional manual library system uses several physical components attached to or kept with each book to identify the book and support its circulation. The components identified during the study include the **book card**, **book pocket**, and **due-date slip**.

13.1 Book Card

The **book card** contains the main identification details of the book, including:

- Class Number
- Accession Number
- Author
- Title

Class No.	Acc. No.
005.74	33887
Author Elmasri, Ramez	
Title Database Systems.	

When the book is available on the library shelf, the book card is kept inside the book pocket.

13.2 Book Pocket

The **book pocket** is attached to the inside of the book. It contains identification details such as the **class number and accession number** and provides a place to keep the book card.

The book pocket therefore keeps the book card physically associated with the relevant book.

WAYAMBA UNIVERSITY OF SRI LANKA LIBRARY	
Class No.	Acc. No.
005.74	33887

13.3 Due-Date Slip

A **due-date table or slip** is attached to the last page or inside back cover of the book. It is used to record or indicate the **date on which the book is due to be returned**.

The photographs examined during the study show several dates entered manually on this table. This provides evidence of the use of the due-date component as part of the manual circulation process.

13.4 Relationship Between the Components

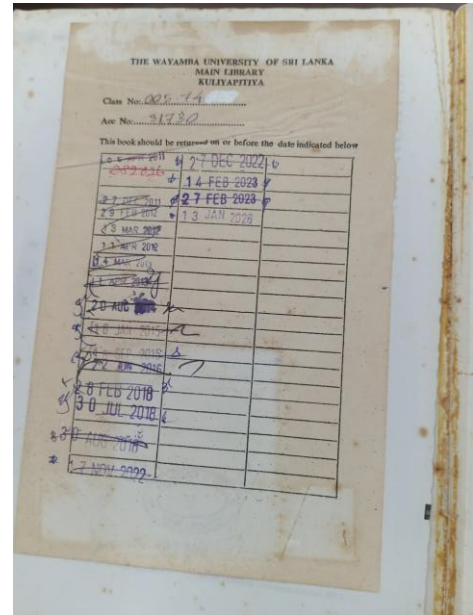
These physical components work together as part of the manual book-circulation system:

Book Card → Identifies the Book

Book Pocket → Stores the Book Card

Due-Date Slip → Indicates the Expected Return Date

Together, these components provide a physical method for identifying books and managing their circulation without depending entirely on a computerized system.



14. Issuing Ticket and Manual Borrowing Procedure

The issuing-ticket system is a central part of the manual borrowing procedure observed at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka.

Each student is provided with **three issuing tickets**. Each ticket contains the student's:

- **Index**
- **Name**
- **Address**
- **Registration Number**

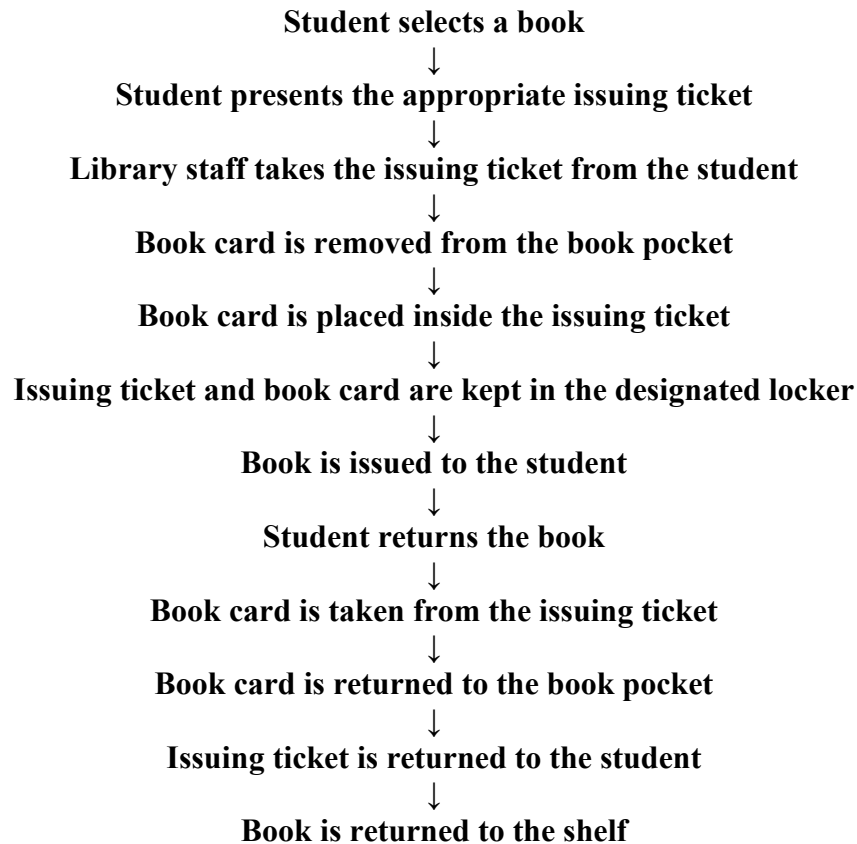
Of the three tickets, **two are blue issuing tickets** used for lending books, while **one is a pink issuing ticket** used for scheduled reference books.

The borrowing periods are:

- **Lending books:** Two weeks
- **Scheduled reference books:** One night
- **Permanent reference books:** Cannot be borrowed and must be used inside the library

14.1 Manual Borrowing Process

The borrowing process observed in the traditional system can be represented as follows:



14.2 Relationship Between the Book and Issuing Ticket

The procedure creates a physical connection between the **borrower and the borrowed book**. The issuing ticket identifies the student, while the book card identifies the particular book.

When a book is borrowed, the **book card is removed from the book pocket and placed inside the student's issuing ticket**. The issuing ticket and book card are then kept together in the designated locker. This creates a physical record linking the borrower with the borrowed book.

When the book is returned, the book card is removed from the issuing ticket and returned to the book pocket. The issuing ticket is then returned to the student, and the book can be returned to its appropriate shelf location.

This procedure is the main physical mechanism used to maintain the connection between **students and borrowed books** in the traditional manual circulation system, without relying on a computerized circulation database.

15. Fine and Charge Records

When library rules require fines or other charges for overdue or unreturned materials, these transactions can be recorded using manual records. Such records help the library keep track of outstanding payments associated with borrowers.

A fine or charge record may contain information such as:

- Borrower number
- Borrower name
- Accession number
- Book title
- Due date
- Return date
- Number of overdue days
- Fine amount
- Amount paid
- Date of payment
- Remarks

These records allow library staff to identify outstanding obligations and maintain a history of fines and payments associated with library users.

In the traditional manual system, maintaining such records accurately is important because the information may also be required when checking a user's **library clearance status**.

16. Stock Control

A library needs to maintain accurate information not only about the books it owns but also about the **current status and location of those books**. Stock control is therefore an important part of library management.

Stock control may involve:

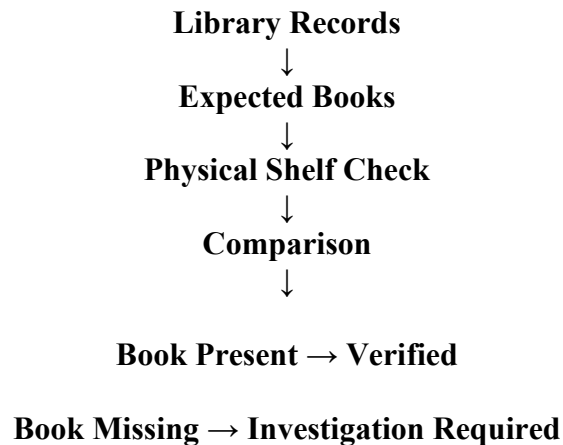
- Checking books on the shelves.
- Identifying missing books.
- Checking books currently on loan.
- Identifying damaged books.
- Identifying lost books.
- Correcting misplaced books.
- Maintaining and updating collection records.

Physical stock control helps the library maintain an accurate collection by comparing the physical availability of books with the relevant library records. It also helps identify books that are missing, misplaced, damaged, or currently issued to users.

17. Stock Verification

Stock verification is the process of checking the physical library collection against the library's records to determine whether the recorded materials can be physically located.

A simplified stock-verification process can be represented as follows:



When a book cannot be found during verification, library staff may investigate possible reasons, such as:

- The book is currently on loan.
- The book has been misplaced.
- The book has been damaged or removed from circulation.
- The book has been lost.

Stock verification is important because physical library collections can become inaccurate over time due to borrowing, returns, misplacement, damage, or loss. Regular verification helps the library identify differences between its physical holdings and recorded information.

18. Shelf Arrangement

After books are returned, they must be placed in their appropriate locations on the library shelves. Proper shelf



arrangement is necessary to ensure that users and library staff can locate books efficiently.

The general process involves:

1. Identifying the book's classification number.
2. Identifying the appropriate shelf or location.
3. Placing the book in the correct sequence.
4. Ensuring that the book is positioned properly with its spine visible.
5. Maintaining the correct order of books on the shelf.

Proper shelving is an important part of stock control. A book that is placed in an incorrect location may be difficult to find even though it is physically present in the library collection. Therefore, accurate shelf arrangement helps maintain the connection between the **library's records, classification system, physical location, and availability of books.**

19. Library Cataloguing

Traditional libraries require a system for organizing bibliographic information so that users can identify and locate books. Before computerized catalogues became common, this function was performed using **physical catalogue cards**.

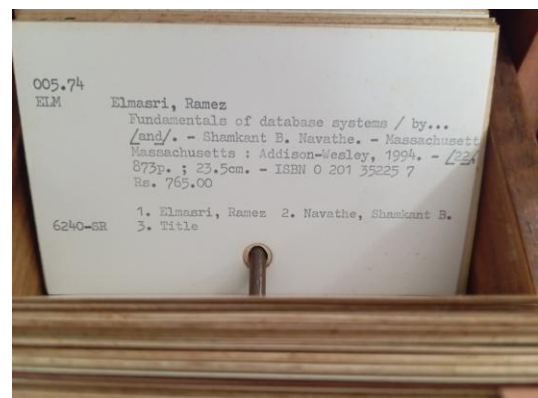
During the study, a **physical card catalogue system** was observed at the library. The catalogue consists of a wooden card-catalogue cabinet containing individual cards with bibliographic information about books. The cards provide details such as the **author, title, classification number, publication information, and other identification details.**

Books can be found through **three main catalogue approaches**:

19.1 Subject Catalogue

Books can be searched according to their **subject**. Subjects are associated with classification numbers, which help users identify the relevant shelf or location of the books.

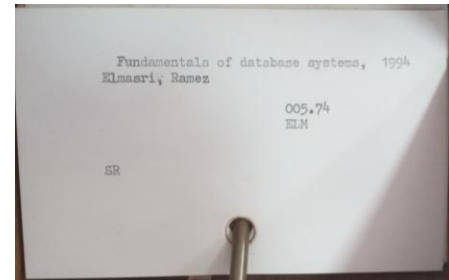
**Subject → Classification Number → Shelf
Location → Book**



19.2 Title Catalogue

Books can also be searched according to their **title**. The title entries are arranged in **alphabetical order (A–Z)**, allowing users to locate a book when its title is known.

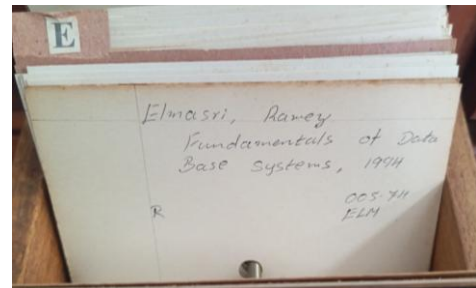
Title → Catalogue Card → Classification Number → Shelf Location → Book



19.3 Author Catalogue

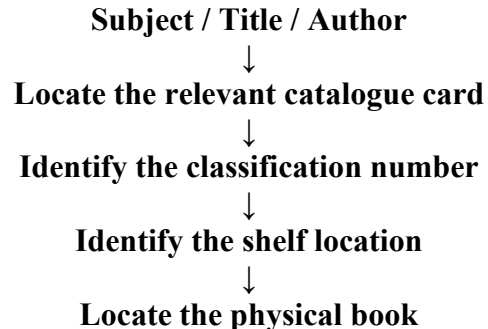
The third method is searching according to the **author's name**. Author entries are also arranged in **alphabetical order (A–Z)**, allowing users to find books written by a particular author.

Author → Catalogue Card → Classification Number → Shelf Location → Book



19.4 Traditional Catalogue Search Process

The overall process can therefore be represented as:



The physical card catalogue therefore acts as a **manual search system** for the library collection. Instead of entering a search query into a computerized library database, users or library staff search the appropriate catalogue section and use the information on the catalogue card to locate the physical book.

The three catalogue approaches, **subject, title, and author**, provide different ways of accessing the same physical collection and demonstrate how information retrieval was managed before computerized library catalogues.

20. Inter-Library Loan System

Another important activity identified in the traditional library system is **Inter-Library Loan (ILL)**. An inter-library loan allows a library to obtain a resource from another library when the required resource is not available in its own collection.

The ILL register identified during the study is divided into two main sections:

1. **Requesting**
2. **Requested from Us**

This division reflects the two roles that the library can perform in an inter-library loan process:

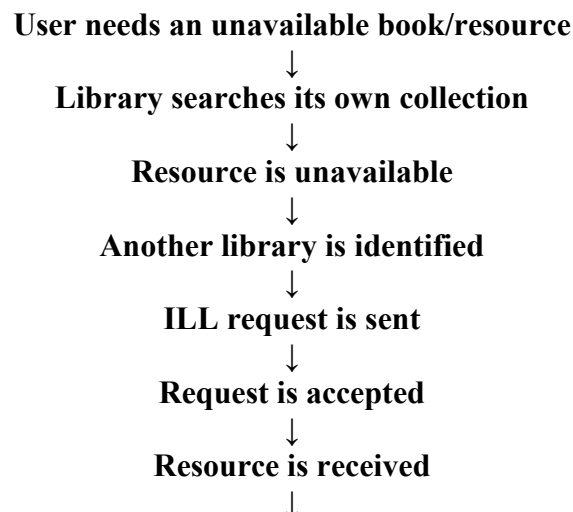
- **Borrowing a resource from another library**
- **Lending a resource to another library**

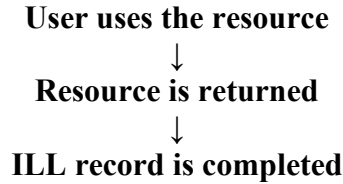
20.1 Requesting

The **Requesting** section records resources requested by the library from other institutions. The fields identified in this section include:

- Date
- Applicant's Name
- Accession number
- Title
- Requesting library
- Requested Date
- Received Date
- Return Date

The process can be represented as:





This record allows the library to track the movement of resources requested from other institutions.

20.2 Requested from Us

The second section, **Requested from Us**, records requests received from other libraries. In this situation, the Wayamba University library acts as the **lending library**.

The record may contain information such as:

- Date
- Accession number
- Title
- Requesting library
- Requester
- Date requested
- Date sent
- Date returned
- Remarks

This section allows the library to maintain a record of resources that temporarily leave its collection for use by another institution.

20.3 Importance of the Inter-Library Loan System

The inter-library loan system supports **resource sharing between libraries**. It allows users to access resources that are not available in their own library while reducing the need for every library to acquire every possible resource.

It supports:

- Resource sharing
- Research and education
- Access to less commonly available materials
- Cooperation between libraries
- More efficient use of library resources and budgets

ILL also creates an additional record-keeping requirement because a physical resource temporarily moves outside its home library. The manual register provides a way to track the **request, movement, receipt, and return** of the resource between the participating libraries.

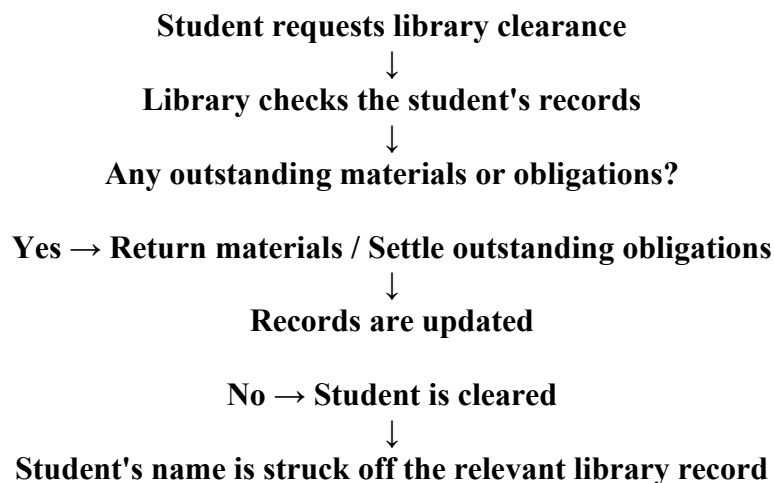
21. Student Library Clearance

Library clearance is an important administrative process carried out when a student completes their studies, leaves the university, or becomes eligible for final clearance. The purpose is to ensure that the student has returned all library materials and has no outstanding library obligations.

The clearance process involves checking:

1. Borrowed books and other library materials.
2. Overdue materials.
3. Lost books.
4. Damaged books.
5. Outstanding fines or charges.
6. Other outstanding library obligations.

A simplified clearance process can be represented as:



When a student has fulfilled all library requirements, the library confirms the student's clearance and **strikes off the student's name from the relevant register or record**. If any books, fines, or other obligations remain outstanding, the student's name remains in the record until the obligations are settled.

This process ensures that students cannot complete their library clearance while they still have outstanding library responsibilities.

22. Staff Library Clearance

A similar clearance procedure is followed for staff members when they leave the university, particularly when a staff member resigns or otherwise requires official clearance.

The library checks the staff member's records for:

- Borrowed books and other library materials.
- Outstanding materials.
- Overdue materials.
- Fines or other charges.
- Other outstanding library obligations.

If the staff member has returned all borrowed materials and has no outstanding obligations, the library can complete the clearance and **strike off the staff member's name from the relevant library record**.

If a staff member resigns while having outstanding fines or other financial obligations to the library, the amount can be **deducted from the staff member's university trust fund** according to the applicable university procedure.

Therefore, staff clearance provides a connection between the library's manual records and the university's administrative procedures for staff leaving the institution.

23. Strengths of the Traditional System

Although the library at the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka now mainly uses a **computerized/online library system**, several physical records and manual procedures continue to be used. The traditional system therefore still has practical value within the present library environment.

23.1 Simple Technology

Many traditional library activities can be carried out using physical materials such as:

- Registers
- Cards
- Book pockets
- Issuing tickets
- Files
- Stamps
- Other stationery

These components do not require computers, internet connectivity, or specialized software for their basic operation.

23.2 Low Technical Dependency

Physical records do not directly depend on computer networks, servers, or database software. Therefore, selected manual activities can continue even when computerized services are temporarily unavailable.

23.3 Easy to Understand

The basic procedures of a physical record system are relatively straightforward. For example, the issuing-ticket and book-card procedure provides a visible connection between a student and a borrowed book.

23.4 Physical Evidence

Physical records provide documentary evidence of library activities. A register, book card, issuing ticket, or other physical document can contain information about a particular user, book, or transaction.

23.5 Historical and Administrative Value

Older physical records can provide valuable information about the development and operation of the library. They may contain historical information about:

- Library users
- Book acquisitions
- Collection development
- Previous library activities
- Institutional records

Physical records that are still actively maintained also continue to serve an administrative purpose.

23.6 Continued Use Alongside the Online System

One important feature identified during this study is that **computerized and physical systems currently operate alongside each other.**

Although the online system is the main system used by the library, selected physical records and procedures are still maintained. These include physical staff-registration records and other selected registers, as well as components such as **book cards, book pockets, and issuing tickets.**

Therefore, the traditional system should not be considered completely discontinued. Instead, some of its components continue to support the library's current operations.

24. Weaknesses of the Traditional System

Despite the continued usefulness of selected physical records, a traditional manual system has several limitations when compared with a computerized library-management system.

24.1 Time-Consuming

Manual activities require library staff to physically locate records, write or check entries, move cards, and maintain documents. This can take more time, particularly when dealing with a large number of users or transactions.

24.2 Human Error

Physical records depend heavily on accurate manual entry and handling. Errors may include:

- Incorrect dates
- Incorrect accession numbers
- Missing entries
- Illegible handwriting
- Incorrect borrower numbers
- Calculation errors

24.3 Difficult Searching

Searching physical registers, cards, and files can take considerable time. Unlike a computerized system, information cannot normally be retrieved instantly by entering a search query.

24.4 Difficult Updating

When information changes, the relevant physical records may need to be updated manually. If the same information exists in several records, maintaining consistency between them can be difficult.

24.5 Physical Storage Requirements

Physical records require dedicated storage space for:

- Registers
- Files
- Catalogue cards
- Book cards
- Historical records
- Forms
- Other documents

The amount of required storage can increase as records accumulate over time.

24.6 Risk of Physical Damage

Paper-based records can be affected by environmental and physical conditions, including:

- Fire
- Water
- Humidity
- Insects
- Dust
- Physical deterioration
- Misplacement

Damage to an important record may result in the loss of information.

24.7 Difficult Statistical Analysis

Producing statistical information manually can require considerable time and effort. For example, calculating:

- Total loans
- Number of overdue books
- Monthly circulation
- Most frequently borrowed books
- Department-wise library usage

may require manual counting or calculation.

24.8 Limited Simultaneous Access

A physical register or card file can only be handled by a limited number of people at the same time. A computerized database, in contrast, can provide simultaneous access to multiple **authorized users**, depending on the system's design.

24.9 Dependence on Physical Handling

The traditional system requires physical movement and careful handling of documents, cards, tickets, and books. Misplacing one of these items can make it more difficult to locate or verify the relevant information.

24.10 Current Situation at Wayamba University

The weaknesses described above do not mean that the traditional system has been completely abandoned at Wayamba University. Rather, the current library environment represents a **combination of computerized and physical systems**.

The **online system is the main system**, while selected physical records and manual components continue to be maintained. Notably, the **student register is no longer used in the same manner as before**, while physical records relating to staff categories and other administrative activities continue to be maintained. The **book card, book pocket, and issuing-ticket system** also remain relevant to the manual circulation process identified in the study.

Thus, the present system can be understood as a **hybrid library-management environment**, where modern computerized methods and selected traditional physical records coexist.

25. Why Old Records Are Still Important

Although the Wayamba University of Sri Lanka now mainly uses a computerized/online library system, older physical records remain valuable. These records provide information about the library's previous activities and can help explain how the library system developed over time.

Old records are important for several reasons:

25.1 Historical Evidence

Old registers, catalogue cards, book cards, and other documents provide evidence of how the library operated in the past. They can show changes in library procedures, collections, and services over different periods.

25.2 Evidence of Previous Library Holdings

Older accession and collection records can help identify books and other resources that were previously added to the library collection. They may also provide information that is not available in current records.

25.3 Verification of Information

When questions arise about an old book, user record, acquisition, or transaction, historical records may provide supporting evidence for verification.

25.4 Institutional History

Physical records can preserve information about the development of the university library, including changes in its collection, users, administrative practices, and services.

25.5 Support for the Transition to Computerization

Old physical records also help demonstrate how the library moved from a manual information-management system towards the present computerized system. They show the types of information that were previously recorded manually and how similar information is now managed electronically.

25.6 Preservation of Institutional Knowledge

Some older procedures and practices may no longer be visible in the current computerized system. Historical records can therefore preserve knowledge about how the library operated before and during the transition to computerization.

However, not all old records can necessarily be accessed or preserved indefinitely. Some records may be restricted because of **privacy, confidentiality, administrative requirements, preservation conditions, or the age and condition of the documents**. Therefore, the available historical records provide valuable evidence, but they may not represent the complete history of every library procedure.

Overall, old physical records should be considered an important part of the library's **documentary and institutional history**, even when the main library operations are now handled through a computerized system.

26. Comparison Between Manual and Computerized Systems

The traditional manual library system and the current computerized system have the same basic purpose of managing **library resources, users, and library activities**. However, the methods used to record, retrieve, and control information are different.

Aspect	Traditional Manual System	Current Computerized / Online System
Record format	Paper registers, cards, files, and physical documents	Electronic records maintained in the library system
Book identification	Accession numbers, book cards, classification numbers, and physical records	Electronic book records and identification information
User registration	Physical registration records and forms	User information maintained electronically
Borrowing	Issuing tickets, book cards, and manual circulation procedures	Borrowing transactions are managed through the computerized system
Book card and book pocket	Used as part of the traditional circulation system	Not currently used
Issuing tickets	Used to control student borrowing	Not currently used
Searching	Physical catalogue cards, registers, and shelf information	Electronic catalogue and computerized searching
Updating information	Information updated manually in physical records	Information updated electronically
Storage	Requires physical space for registers, cards, and files	Information stored electronically
Statistical work	Often requires manual counting and calculation	Can be generated and processed electronically

Access to records	Requires physical access to the relevant document	Authorized users can access electronic information through the system
Technical dependency	Low dependence on computers and networks	Depends on computer, software, database, and network infrastructure
Historical evidence	Provides original physical records of past activities	Provides electronic records of current activities

26.1 Relationship Between the Two Systems

The current computerized system performs many functions that were previously carried out through physical records.

For example, in the traditional circulation system, the relationship between a student and a borrowed book was physically maintained through:

Student → Issuing Ticket → Book Card → Borrowed Book

In the computerized system, this relationship is maintained electronically through:

User Record → Electronic Borrowing Transaction → Book Record

Similarly, the traditional physical catalogue allowed users to locate books through catalogue cards, while the current system provides an **electronic search facility**.

26.2 Physical Records Still Used Today

Although the computerized/online system is now the **main system used by the library**, some physical records continue to be maintained for administrative and supporting purposes.

These include selected records such as:

- **Staff registration records**
- **Administrative registers**
- **Loan-related records**
- **Fine records**
- **Lost and Paid records**
- **Other selected library registers**

Therefore, the transition to computerization has **not resulted in the complete disappearance of physical records**. Instead, selected paper-based records continue to support particular administrative and financial activities.

26.3 Traditional Components No Longer in Use

Some of the physical components identified during the study belong to the **previous traditional circulation system** and are no longer used in the current library operation.

These include:

- **Book cards**
- **Book pockets**
- **Issuing tickets**

These components are nevertheless important to this study because they demonstrate how the traditional manual borrowing system operated before the current computerized process.

26.4 Current Library Environment

The present library system at Wayamba University can therefore be understood as a **computerized system supported by selected physical records**.

The traditional circulation mechanism based on **book cards, book pockets, and issuing tickets** has been replaced by computerized borrowing procedures. However, certain administrative and supporting records, such as **staff registers, fine records, lost-and-paid records, loan-related records, and other selected registers**, continue to be maintained physically.

This demonstrates the transition from a predominantly manual library system to a computerized system while also showing that **physical records can continue to have specific administrative functions even after computerization**.

Feature	Traditional System	Computerized System
User registration	Paper register	Database
Book registration	Accession register	Bibliographic database
Borrowing	Cards/registers	Computer transaction
Identification	Library card/ticket	Barcode/Rfid/member ID
Search	Physical catalogue	Online catalogue
Due-date calculation	Manual	Automatic
Overdue tracking	Manual	Automatic
Statistics	Manual calculation	Automatic reports
Stock verification	Physical checking	Database + QR checking
Inter-library loan	Paper records	Electronic workflows
Clearance	Manual checking	Automated account checking
Storage	Physical files	Digital database
Backup	Duplicate paper copies or no backup	Digital backup also paper copies
Searching	Slow	Fast
Human error	Relatively high	Reduced but not eliminated
Infrastructure	Low technology	Requires IT infrastructure
Access	Physical	Potentially multiple simultaneous users

27. Conclusion

The study of the traditional physical library card system at the **Wayamba University of Sri Lanka** provided an understanding of how library resources, users, and transactions were managed through physical records and manual procedures. The system depended on interconnected components such as registration records, accession records, catalogue cards, book cards, book pockets, issuing tickets, registers, and other documentary records.

The study also demonstrated how the traditional borrowing system controlled different categories of library materials. **Lending books, schedule reference books, and permanent reference books** were subject to different borrowing conditions. The former issuing-ticket system, together with book cards and book pockets, created a physical connection between the borrower and the borrowed book.

Other activities, including **stock control, stock verification, library cataloguing, inter-library loans, fine management, and student and staff clearance**, also required systematic record keeping. These activities demonstrate that the traditional library system functioned as a structured information-management system even though it did not use a computerized database.

The study further showed that the library has undergone a transition from the traditional manual system to a **computerized/online system**. The online system is currently the main system used for library operations. However, selected physical records, including **staff registration records, administrative registers, loan-related records, fine records, lost-and-paid records, and other selected registers**, continue to be maintained for particular purposes. At the same time, former circulation components such as **book cards, book pockets, and issuing tickets are no longer used**.

The remaining historical records are valuable because they provide evidence of the library's previous practices, collections, users, and administrative activities. Although access to some older records was limited because of privacy, confidentiality, preservation, and administrative restrictions, the available records provided useful evidence for understanding the development of the library system.

Overall, the study shows the transition from a **predominantly physical, manual information-management system to a computerized library system**, while also demonstrating that selected physical records continue to have administrative and historical value. The traditional system therefore represents an important part of the development and institutional history of the library at Wayamba University of Sri Lanka.